PRACTITIONER REFERENCE

Scalp Conditions Cheat Sheet

Know what you're looking at, when to go gentle and when to refer.

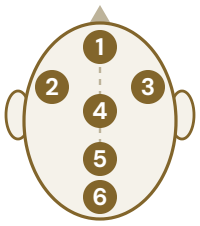
Scalp types & conditions

CONDITION	WHAT YOU MAY SEE (SCOPE OR EYE)	HEAD SPA
Dry	Fine white flakes, tightness, dull lengths	OK
Oily	Shine, clumped strands, oil pooling at follicles	OK
Buildup	Waxy film or plugs around follicles	OK
Sensitive	Pinkness, quick flushing, stings with products	**Gentle only**
Dandruff	Small white flakes, mild itch, no redness	OK
Seborrheic dermatitis	Greasy yellow scale with redness, often hairline	**Gentle only**
Psoriasis	Thick silvery plaques with sharp edges	**Gentle only**
Folliculitis	Red or pus-filled bumps around follicles	**Refer**
Tinea capitis (ringworm)	Round scaly patches, broken hairs, black dots	**Refer**
Head lice	Nits glued near the root, live lice, scratching	**Refer**
Traction alopecia	Thinning at hairline or temples from tight styles	**Gentle only**
Pattern thinning	Widening part or thin crown; finer hairs	OK, suggest derm
Alopecia areata	Smooth, round bald patches	**Refer**

Product types

PRODUCT TYPE	BEST FOR	AVOID IF
Carbonated (CO2)	Oily scalp, buildup, a fresh deep cleanse	Broken or very dry skin
Clay	Oily scalp, heavy buildup, odor	Dry, flaky or sensitive scalp
Enzyme or fine scrub	Buildup, dry flakes, before a mask	Inflamed, sunburned; chemical <[72] h
Oil	Dry, tight scalp; massage; loosening flakes	Seborrheic flare; nut allergy (check oil)
Cream or mask	Dry or sensitive scalp, after exfoliation	Fragrance allergy; fine oily hair

Microscope zones



1 Front hairline
2 Left temple
3 Right temple
4 Part or top
5 Crown
6 Nape

Look for: oil, flakes or buildup, redness, follicle openings, hair density and diameter, breakage.

Every time: [50–200]x, same zones before and after; client sees images; stored privately.

POSITIONING

- **Neck supported** and neutral; no sharp tilt.
- Ask about neck problems, vertigo, past stroke.
- Dizzy, seeing spots, numb: stop; sit up slowly.
- Severe headache, slurred speech, droop: 911.

WATER & HEAT

- **Wrist test** the water every time.
- Lukewarm [95–104°F] for the scalp.
- Cascade at gentle pressure, away from eyes.
- Steam: distilled water, maker's distance.

Specialists don't diagnose. Refer to a dermatologist when in doubt. Never promise regrowth.